Nicolas Polasek

Ph.D. Student, Agricultural and Resource Economics, University of California, Berkeley
207 Giannini Hall, Berkeley, CA 94720-3310
nicolas_polasek@berkeley.edu

Education

University of California, Berkeley August 2021 - May 2027 (expected)
Ph.D. in Agricultural and Resource Economics

University of Geneva September 2017 - June 2019
M.Sc. in Economics

University of Geneva September 2012 - June 2016
B.A. in International Relations

Research Fields

Primary: Development Economics **Secondary:** Labor Economics

References

Jeremy Magruder
Dept. of Agricultural and Resource Economics
University of California, Berkeley
jmagruder@berkeley.edu

Marco Gonzalez-Navarro
Dept. of Agricultural and Resource Economics
University of California, Berkeley
marcog@berkeley.edu

Edward Miguel
Dept. of Economics
University of California, Berkeley
emiguel@berkeley.edu

Job Market Paper

Market Integration and the Effects of Forced Displacement on Host Communities
Draft coming soon

Abstract. About half of forcibly displaced people worldwide are hosted in rural communities, where integration with external markets is often limited. This paper studies how market integration shapes host communities' responses to internal displacement in Ethiopia, where conflict displaced more than four million people between 2018 and 2022. I develop a stylized framework in which hosts produce and consume food, traded on external markets, and services that are locally supplied. Displacement expands consumer demand and low-skill labor supply, inducing hosts to enter high-skill occupations. In the framework, lower market integration limits host reallocation and causes food prices to decline. The empirical analysis instruments displacement inflows with a shift-share design that combines the origins of an area's pre-existing displaced population with subsequent conflict shocks in those origins. Displacement inflows cause a decline in low-skill wages and non-food prices. However, adjustment depends on market integration. In more integrated communities, hosts move out of agriculture and casual labor into higher-skill, non-agricultural occupations. In less integrated communities, occupational reallocation is limited. Instead, hosts hire more workers and expand agricultural production, leading food prices to decline more sharply. Host real consumption rises in both types of communities, with larger gains in less integrated areas. These findings suggest that displacement can increase host consumption through lower labor costs, with market integration shaping how communities adjust.

Work in Progress

The Social Penalty of Underemployment
with Eric Ochieng and Frederick Aila
Funding secured

The Effect of Cash Transfers and Village Savings Groups on Youth in Rural Settings: Evidence from the DRC
with Jeremy Magruder and Eleanor Wiseman
Experiment finalized

Natural Disasters and Social Policy: Evidence from Goma's Youths
with Jeremy Magruder and Eleanor Wiseman
Experiment finalized

How Does Agricultural Mechanization Affect Labor Markets in Sub-Saharan Africa: The Case of Tractor Services in Nigeria

Teaching Experience

University of California, Berkeley
Graduate Student Instructor

Applied Statistics 1 (COMPSS 212)	Fall 2025
Introductory Applied Econometrics (EEP 118)	Fall 2024
Development Economics (EEP C151)	Fall 2022

Research Assistance

Graduate Student Researcher, University of California, Berkeley — 2025
Jeremy Magruder; spring and fall semesters

Graduate Student Researcher, University of California, Berkeley — 2024
Jeremy Magruder and Supreet Kaur; spring semester

Graduate Student Researcher, University of California, Berkeley — 2023
Ellen Bruno

Research Assistant, University of Geneva — 2021
Giacomo De Giorgi and Salvatore Di Falco

Other Professional Experience

Consultant - Research Assistant, The World Bank — 2024

Lead for Monitoring and Evaluation — 2020-2021
Centre Ecologique Albert Schweitzer, Switzerland

Associate, Economic Security Unit — 2019-2020
International Committee of the Red Cross

Awards, Fellowships, and Grants

2026	Research Grant, Giannini Foundation for Agricultural Economics	$34,736.75
	Research Grant, Weiss Fund for Research in Development Economics	$14,430
	Merit Grant, Swiss Benevolent Society of San Francisco	$5,000
2025	Research Grant, Giannini Foundation for Agricultural Economics	$25,000
	Student Opportunity Fund, UC Berkeley Student Union	$1,000
2024	Development Economics Challenge, Center for Effective Global Action	$5,500
	Sacheti Family Grant, UC Berkeley Department of Agricultural and Resource Economics	$3,000
2022-2023	Travel Grants, UC Berkeley Department of Agricultural and Resource Economics (two awards)	$1,500 each
2019	Best Master's Dissertation Award, Economics Department, University of Geneva	CHF 1,000
2016	Scholarship, Fondation Barbour	CHF 10,000

Presentations

North East Universities Development Consortium annual conference, Ithaca, New York	2026
Center for Effective Global Action (CEGA) Research Retreat, Berkeley, California	2026
Development Economics Seminar, University of California, Berkeley	2026
Agricultural and Resource Economics Departmental Seminar, University of California, Berkeley	2026
Development Economics Lunch, University of California, Berkeley (five presentations)	2024-2026
Development Workshop, University of California, Berkeley (five presentations)	2024-2026
Giannini Foundation of Agricultural and Resource Economics Student Conference (GARESC), Berkeley, California	2024
Africa Evidence Summit, Dar es Salaam, Tanzania (poster)	2024

Service and Mentoring

UC Berkeley ARE Ph.D. Admissions Committee, Committee Member	2025
CEGA African Visiting Fellow Program, Peer Ph.D. Partner for Dr. Isaac Doku, Lecturer at the University of Education, Winneba, Ghana	2024
Undergraduate Honors Thesis Mentor, Lakshmi Gopinathan, University of California, Berkeley	2024

Refereeing

Journal of Development Economics, Journal of Development Studies

Languages

French (native), English (fluent), Italian (fluent), Spanish (intermediate), German (elementary)

Last updated: October 29, 2026